Antanas Juška — Lietuviškos svotbinės dainos (Lithuanian Wedding Songs, 1883)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Antanas Juška, the Lithuanian priest who wrote down some seven thousand songs as the people sang them, parish by parish, dialect and melody together. He did part of that work after 1863, when he was arrested and held about nine months in Kaunas Prison on suspicion of sympathising with the uprising. It is also dedicated to his elder brother Jonas, who obtained the exemptions that let Lithuanian be printed in Latin letters under the press ban, and who carried the wedding songs into print after Antanas's death.

The story

Antanas Juška was born on 16 June 1819 at Daujotai, near Ariogala, to landless Samogitian nobles. His elder brother Jonas educated him and got him into Kražiai College, from which he passed to the Vilnius Theological Seminary and was ordained a Catholic priest in 1843. He then served in a string of Lithuanian parishes and school posts, collecting songs and vocabulary as he went. In total he recorded about 7,000 Lithuanian folk songs, of which only about 2,800 were ever published.

Jonas Juška (1815–1886) was a teacher and linguist who taught in Russian

cities, barred as a Catholic from a post in Lithuania. In 1875 he settled in Kazan and obtained leave to print Lithuanian in Latin letters and a special exemption from Tsar Alexander II for the wedding-song volume. Antanas joined him in Kazan in 1879 and died there on 1 November 1880, after thirteen months of work, with only the first segment of his collection in print. Jonas then devoted the rest of his life to his brother's works and died in May 1886.

The work and what survives

The wedding songs are one of four large song volumes published in 1880–1883 in the Latin alphabet despite the Tsarist Lithuanian press ban. Three volumes of Lithuanian songs, 1,586 in total, came from the University of Kazan in 1880–1882, and the wedding-song volume of about 1,100 songs came from the Russian Academy of Sciences at St. Petersburg in 1883. The volume is arranged in three parts — before the wedding, during it, and the return — with ritual sections for the wooing, the matchmaking, the betrothal, the maiden's evening, the dowry-carting, the church-going, the bedding, the headdressing, and the *karvojus*, the wedding bread. Its Lithuanian text carries Russian summaries interleaved.

Antanas's Lithuanian–Polish dictionary ran to about 70,000 words in full and was never finished; the portion published in 1897, 1904, and 1922, reaching *kuokštuotis*, ran to about 30,000 words.

What this project holds is a completed selection. Forty songs stand in fresh, plain English, numbered 1 to 40 and drawn from all three parts, with places obscured in the scan marked rather than invented. The rendering was made from the Lithuanian verses, not the Russian summaries, from the Internet Archive digitisation of the 1883 printing. Its label governs its state: "DRAFT — NOT SHELVED. FURTHER CHECKS PENDING."

Its English fortunes

The folder's finding, at its full strength, is this: **No Englishing of the Wedding Songs found after research.** The pin pass found none either. What the searches found instead was the volume's life in other languages: Russian translations in an 1867 booklet of 33 songs, a melodies volume from Antanas's

collecting published at Kraków in 1900 with Polish and German title forms, and the 1883 volume itself listed in Lithuanian by The Online Books Page, with no English edition there. The bound must be carried plainly: those searches were web searches, the brothers' biographical records, that listing, and the folder's primacy note. No WorldCat or union-catalogue edition-graph check was run, so this is a "none found after research" finding, and nothing stronger is claimed.

What completing it would take

Completing the volume would mean Englishing the roughly 1,060 songs beyond the forty of the present selection — a programme about twenty-six times the selection's size. It should not be done the way the selection had to be done: the selection worked from raw OCR of a printing in the brothers' phonetic, pre-reform orthography, its two-column layout interleaved line by line by the OCR. A completion should work from page images, with a Lithuanian-reading reviser. It would also need the checks the draft label demands, including independent audit and the editor's approval, and a ruling on whether the Russian summaries are to be Englished as apparatus or left aside, as the selection left them. Until then, the forty keep their honest description: forty of about eleven hundred, chosen by an editor.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/juska-lithuanian-wedding-songs-selection/juska-lithuanian-wedding-songs-selection.txt
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Antanas_Ju%C5%A1ka
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